

Few, a few, little, and a little

Teaching guide

Express a small amount with the intended emphasis.

Understand the distinction

Use few and a few for small numbers of countable plural nouns. Use little and a little for small amounts of an uncountable noun. Few/little often stress a shortage; a few/a little stress that some are available.

Context decides whether an amount is enough. A few does not promise a sufficient number. Little can also be an adjective meaning small, as in little houses or little people; that is a different use from the quantity word.

Compare the patterns

SMALL NUMBER

I have a few questions.

There are some questions.

SHORTAGE

We have little time.

The speaker emphasizes the small amount.

SOME AVAILABLE

We have a little time.

The speaker emphasizes that some time remains.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose for an amount: a little advice / a few advice

2. Which usually sounds more positive: few friends / a few friends?

3. Must little houses mean a small number of houses?

Use it in your own life

Describe a small amount you have and a shortage you face.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. a little advice

Advice is normally uncountable.

2. a few friends

It emphasizes having some friends.

3. No. It normally means small houses.

Little can describe physical size.

One possible response

I have a little time this evening, but few free hours this week.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-27.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe a small amount you have and a shortage you face.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.